

VISUAL TOUR

GATLING GUN

By the second half of the 19th century, improvements in engineering had made it possible to manufacture reliable rapid-fire weapons. This gun, patented by Richard Gatling in 1862, employed multiple barrels, as would all early machine-guns (see pp.136–37). It was first developed during the American Civil War and was deemed a success.

1
Foresight and barrels

2
Magazine slot

► **PROTOTYPE MACHINE-GUN**
The gun's barrels—at first six, later 10 (as shown here)—were arranged around a cylindrical shaft. A hand-operated crank made the barrels revolve, and cartridges dropped into place from above as each barrel came around. A firing pin then struck and fired the bullet; the barrel turned and the process was repeated. As each barrel descended, its spent case was ejected. This is a prototype of one of Gatling's guns. It fired 400 rounds per minute.

3
Anti-rotation pawl

5
Wheel hub

Cotter

GATLING GUN

Date 1865

Origin US

Barrel 26½in (67.3cm)

Caliber .45in, .65in, or 1in

